

Approaches to Experimental Methodologies to Study Stigmatized Languages: The Case of Ecuadorian Andean Spanish

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Abstract

The difficulty of obtaining quantitative evidence under controlled experimental conditions is exponentially increased when the language under study is highly stigmatized, and its speakers are aware of its stigma. In this paper, we describe the difficulties encountered in designing experimental tasks to study focus-marking strategies in Ecuadorian Andean Spanish (EAS). EAS is an emblem of the indigenous people of Ecuador and is frequently associated with an ideal rural, poor, uneducated, indigenous speaker. EAS differs from Ecuadorian Spanish (the standard spoken by the non-indigenous majority in Ecuador) in the level of influence of Kichwa, the Quechua language of Ecuador. We use EAS as a case study to examine the role of language ideologies in the participants' performance in controlled experimental settings and to discuss possible solutions to overcome the difficulties derived from such complex sociolinguistic pictures. Specifically, we introduce what we dub the *Community-Based Approach* and the *Saving-Face Approach* to experimental methodologies. These approaches allow participants to, first, fall into everyday speech practices and, second, to detach themselves from the stigma carried by their language. Together, these approaches to experimental methodologies lead to a collection of data that accurately portrays the participants' grammar.

Key words: linguistic ideologies, Ecuadorian Andean Spanish, experimental approaches, information structure

1. Introduction

Sociolinguistic interviews and ethnographic work are crucial to unveil speakers' linguistic attitudes and establish variation patterns. However, when trying to unveil a language's grammar and support linguistic claims, we often rely on experimental designs allowing us to obtain quantitative evidence under controlled conditions. In this paper, the two worlds collide. We address the challenges of designing experimental tasks to gather quantitative data when working with speakers of highly stigmatized language varieties, who are very much aware of the linguistic and racial ideologies surrounding them. We focus on Ecuadorian Andean Spanish (EAS), a stigmatized Spanish variety that is highly influenced by Kichwa (the Quechua language of Ecuador). In this paper we introduce two approaches to experimental methodologies developed to overcome the observer's paradox, which is exponentially amplified in the case of speakers highly aware of the stigma of their language, the *Community-Based* (CBA) and the *Saving-Face* (SFA) Approaches to experimental methodologies. Both approaches combined address the complex issues raised by speaker language awareness in marginalized minority languages. First, the CBA involves working directly with community members in the design of experimental tasks, getting their feedback to recreate naturalistic settings to make participants feel at ease and thus more easily use spontaneous speech. Second, the SFA allows us to obtain native speakers

judgements of everyday language without participants feeling responsible for what is otherwise considered an incorrect way of speaking. These approaches are detailed in section 5. The overall take-home message of our investigation is that researchers working with stigmatized language varieties should get to know the speech community they are working with and make creative use of such knowledge. In these complex sociolinguistic settings, it is crucial to capitalize on the community's everyday linguistic practices in developing experimental tasks. By getting immersed in everyday practices participants relax the level of awareness of their own speech leading to a data collection that more accurately represents the participants' actual linguistic patterns.

The reminder of this paper is organized as follows: in section 2 we present an overview of the sociolinguistic situation in Ecuador and the ideologies present in the speech community under study. We then present the theoretical assumptions regarding information structure guiding our experimental hypotheses, section 3. In section 4 and 5 we introduce the different experimental designs developed to address the empirical questions, the challenges faced and the principles behind the solutions. We finish in section 6 with some observations about the methodologies proposed.

2. The linguistic landscape of Ecuador: Kichwa, Ecuadorian Andean Spanish, and the “standard”

Ecuador is a multilingual nation-state. Spanish is its official language, but the Ecuadorian Constitution recognizes two indigenous languages as official for intercultural relations, Kichwa¹ and Shuar (2008 Constitution, Art. 2), which are, together with other eleven languages, the languages of the pre-colonial civilizations inhabiting the land of today's Ecuador. There are currently one million Kichwa speakers, most of whom also speak a variety Spanish.

In the Ecuadorian Highlands, Spanish and Kichwa have been in sustained and intense contact over the years. We call *Ecuadorian Spanish* (ES) the variety of Spanish spoken by the idealized non-indigenous Ecuadorian living in urban areas with access to economic means and education (an ideal non-indigenous speaker, typically mestizo and/or white, at the top of the socio-economic hierarchy, and long detached from the indigenous communities). ES sets the standard, the level of appropriateness, against which other varieties of Spanish spoken in Ecuador are measured.² ES is influenced by Kichwa and thus differs from other Spanish varieties on linguistic features at the phonetic, lexical, morphological, syntactic, and semantic/pragmatic levels. This can be observed, for example, in the mirative uses of the present perfect, in the use of the verbal periphrasis *dar+gerund* (lit. give + gerund form) to convey orders (expressed in other Spanish varieties canonically by using the imperative verb morphology), or in the use of the future form to address an attenuated command or suggestion (e.g., *comprarasle flores*; lit. you will buy him flowers, ≈ ‘Buy him flowers’). EAS, however, presents a higher resemblance with Kichwa (Haboud, 1998; Toscano, 1953). EAS shares the Kichwa features mentioned above for ES (e.g., *dar+gerund*, mirative, etc.) and, additionally, shows other features that, given their absence in ES, are usually stigmatized. For example, at the phonological level, EAS shows differences with ES and other

¹ Kichwa is the Quechua language spoken in Ecuador. We will follow the spelling used by the Ecuadorian constitution (2008, Art. 2)

² There is yet a higher standard in Ecuador, the variety spoken by the idealized Castilian speaker (see Flores Mejía 2014).

Spanish varieties regarding vocalic and consonantal sounds as a result of the convergence process between Kichwa and Spanish (e.g., the word *carro* ‘car’, is pronounced as [karo] in ES but as [kaɾo] or [kaɾio] in EAS; see, e.g., Haboud & de la Vega 2008; Muysken 2019).³ At the lexical level, EAS also makes use of loanwords from Kichwa (e.g., *achachay* ‘it’s cold’) and of information-structure particles like *-ka* (e.g., *Lupita-ka libros compró* lit. ‘Lupita-ka books bought’).

Since EAS deviates from the norm, the “superior” variety set by ES, EAS is judged as incorrect. Crucially, EAS is also an emblem of indigeneity, i.e., speaking EAS identifies the speaker as indigenous, and given the sway and support from racial ideologies, EAS speakers are perceived as rural, uneducated, and poor in a second order of indexation (Silverstein 2003). Furthermore, speaking a “deviant” form of Spanish, a form that differs from the ES standard, leads to the perception of EAS as deficient, reinforcing the racial ideologies that regard indigenous speakers themselves as deficient. That is, ideologies link differences in linguistic features to cultural images and lead to powerful and convincing constructions of stereotypes of people and activities (Gal & Irvine 2019). Conversely, being an indigenous person triggers the perception of their speech as deficient by the larger dominant culture. In sum, ideologies of language and race support and reinforce each other: language shapes the perception of race and vice versa (see, e.g., Flores and Rosa 2015). This said, EAS is also spoken by non-indigenous people in close contact with indigenous people through social networks such as those within the trade environment in the local markets.⁴ The low regard that ES speakers in general hold for EAS and their speakers can be observed in the metalinguistic comments found in common disparaging speech (see, e.g., the mock-language speech acts found in social media memes studied in Narváez-Burbano 2023).

The conclusion from the discussion above is that standard language ideologies together with racial ideologies present in the dominant culture in Ecuador (i.e., the culture of the majority non-indigenous population) and their interrelation results on the stigmatization of indigenous people and their social practices (linguistic or otherwise). Furthermore, EAS speakers are very aware of the stigma carried out by their language variety and this awareness affects their everyday interactions with people outside of their speech community (or community of practice). At the scientific level, the EAS speakers’ awareness of the stigma carried out by their Spanish variety posits a problem for the researcher when trying to gather quantitative data unveiling the grammar of EAS. Speakers often make all possible efforts to modify their speech to avoid EAS features that they know are the object of mockery or metalinguistic comments from ES speakers. This is exactly the problem we found in our attempt to gather data to understand the different focus-marking strategies and the role of the morpheme *-ka* in EAS.

Previous studies have mentioned that the use of *-ka* is a unique feature in EAS and its contribution to the discourse is related to the notions of information structure (Lipski, 2014; Muysken, 2019; Puma Ninacuri, 2022). Most of the studies used sociolinguistic interviews, but none have included controlled experiments that support previous and often contradictory claims. In the following section we first overview the minimal necessary theoretical assumptions in addressing focus marking and the

³ Although several of these features are widespread for EAS throughout the Ecuadorian Highlands, some characteristics may differ from one city to another due to different factors such as the sociohistorical context of the place (e.g., linguistic contact, colonization processes), internal and external migratory movements, as well as intense processes of modernization and globalization (Haboud & de la Vega, 2008).

⁴ Social stratification in Ecuador is a complex issue that we cannot further examine in this paper.

role of *-ka* in EAS, and then describe the approaches to experimental methodologies developed to overcome the observer's paradox when dealing with stigmatized languages in controlled experiments.

3. Information Structure

The discussion regarding the approaches to experimental methodologies described in the next section were developed while designing tasks to study focus marking strategies in EAS. Specifically, we address word order and the Kichwa particle *-ka*, present in EAS and claimed to be used to indicate the information structure status of the constituent it attaches to. In Kichwa speakers have morphemes at their disposal to signal the information-structure status of constituents, e.g., to signal what part of the utterance was taken to be at-issue (the main point of the utterance) and what part was not (see, e.g., Chafe 1976).

Much of the literature on information structure involves discussion of *focus*. We assume that the constituent marked as the focus in the sentence is the constituent evoking alternatives relevant to the interpretation in discourse (see, e.g., Rooth 1992, Krifka 2008). Different languages have different means to mark the information-structure status of sentential constituents. For example, in English prosodic means are employed to mark an element as focused (small caps below indicate what is made salient via prosodic means). Word order is also an important strategy, and this is what we find in Spanish varieties, like Ecuadorian Spanish (ES) (recall that Spanish is an SVO language). In contrast, Kichwa (an SOV agglutinative language) uses morphemes instead. In this paper, we report data from Central Kichwa, specifically from Salcedo (Cotopaxi Province) and Northern Kichwa, specifically from Chirihuasi (Imbabura Province). In these varieties, the morpheme *-mi* optionally attaches to the constituent evoking alternatives relevant to the interpretation. This is easily observed in Question-Answer pairs, where congruence constraints require that the alternatives that the speaker marks as relevant in the answer correspond to the alternatives that the question entertain/ask about. In (1) and (2) no other placement is possible for *-mi*. (The (a) examples below are the Kichwa responses, while the (b) examples are the ES parallels.):

- (1) A: Pitak chayamu-rka-n? / ¿Quién llegó? [K/ES]
Quién llegar-past-3sg who arrive-past.3sg
 a. B: Christian-**mi** chayamu-rka-n. [K]
Christian-mi arrive-past-3sg
 b. B: Christian llegó. [ES]
Christian arrive-past.3sg
 'CHRISTIAN arrived.'
- (2) A: Tanta-ta-wan-ka ima-tak tuku-rka-n? / ¿Qué pasó con el pan? [K/ES]
pan-AC-with-ka what-Q happen-past-3s what happen-past-3sg with the bread
 'What happened with the bread?'
 a. B: Christian (tanta-ta-ka) miku-rka-ni-**mi**. [K]
Christian (bread-AC-ka) eat-past-3sg-mi
 b. B: Christian se comió el pan. [ES]
Christian cl.3sg eat.pas.3sg the bread
 'Christian ATE it up.'

In (1A) the question inquires about the person who arrived, e.g., the alternatives relevant for the interpretation are alternatives that vary with respect to whom (may have) arrived. For example, imagine that in the context of utterance Christian, María and Patricia are the only people that might have arrived. The meaning of the interrogative is the set of possible answers to the question and, thus, the set containing the alternatives that Christian arrived, that María arrived, and that Patricia arrived, i.e., alternatives varying on the person who arrived. The utterance of the interrogative sentence requests that the addressee establishes which of them is true. In their answer, (1a) marks *Christian* as the element evoking alternatives for the interpretation by attaching *-mi* to it. By marking *Christian* with *-mi*, the speaker signals that other possible utterances may have varied with respect to that element (i.e., on the person who arrived), making the response congruent with the inquiry: the alternatives deemed relevant for the interpretation of the answer overlap with the alternatives entertained by the question. Overall, (1a) conveys that amongst the contextually available alternatives, that Christian arrived is true (and since the speaker doesn't mention anyone else having arrived, the inference is that nobody else did). Any other position of *-mi* in (1a) results in an infelicitous response because it would result in incongruence (roughly, there would be a discursive dissonance between what B considers the main point of the utterance in the response, what is at-issue, and A's considerations). Inserting *-mi* is optional, and by choosing to include *-mi* the speaker triggers 'emphasis'. This is because by choosing to use *-mi*, the speaker further signals that the claim that it was Christian who arrived is based on first-hand/best-grounds evidence. This precisification triggers the 'emphasis' inference. That is, by using *-mi* the speaker is not just committing to the information conveyed, which would have been done without *-mi* as well, rather, with *-mi* the speaker also conveys that the commitment made is the result of having first-hand/best-grounds evidence.⁵ Similarly, in (2a) we can see that the question differs on what may have happened with the bread. The possible alternatives making up the meaning of the question vary on the verb-predicate, and this is indeed where *-mi* is attached in (2a)'s response, making it congruent.

In this paper we are concerned with an additional Kichwa morpheme, *-ka*, which is illustrated in the interrogative in (2A), and in the response in (2a). It has been claimed in the literature that *-ka* in Kichwa is a topic marker in the Strawson sense (aboutness topic). That is, *-ka* attaches to the element the utterance is about: *-ka* signals that the information conveyed is to be filed as information about the element it attaches to. For example, in (2A) the speaker is requesting information about the bread and the response in (2Ba) is that it must be recorded about the bread that Christian ate it up. Importantly, just as with *-mi*, the presence of *-ka* is optional and by placing *-ka* the speaker triggers the inference ('emphasizes') that it is about that marked element, and no other, that the information provided is predicated. Importantly, *-mi* and *-ka* are in complementary distribution, lending support to the view that *-mi* is a focus marker and *-ka* a topic marker (in approaches in which "topic" is considered a basic notion of information structure). Similar facts can be observed in (3) and (4) below:

- | | | | | |
|--------|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|------------------|--------|
| (3) A: | Christian-ka chayamu-rka-chu? | / ¿Llegó | Christian? | [K/ES] |
| | <i>Christian-ka arrive-past-Q</i> | <i>arrive.pas.3sg</i> | <i>Christian</i> | [ES] |
| a. B: | (Ari.) Christian-ka chayamu-rka-n-mi | | | [K] |
| | <i>sí</i> | <i>Christian-ka llegar-past-3-mi</i> | | |

⁵ The morpheme *-mi* is said to double best-grounds/direct evidential and focus marking. Kichwa, as a Quechua language, has an evidential system to mark direct/best-grounds evidence (*-mi*), indirect evidence (*-si*) and conjecture (*-chu*).

- b. B: Sí, Christian llegó. [ES]
yes Christian arrive.pas.3sg
 ‘Yes, Christian arrived.’
- (4) Christian, imatak miku-rka-n? / ¿Qué comió Christian? [K/ES]
Christian what comer-past-3sg what eat.pas.3sg Christian
- a. B: Christian-ka tanta-ta(-mi) miku-rka-n [K]
Christian-ka bread-AC-mi eat-past-3sg
- b. B: Christian pan comió. [ES]
Christian bread eat.pas.3sg
 ‘Christian ate BREAD.’

As seen above, the question and the answer must be congruent and, hence, the alternatives entertained in the inquiry must overlap with the alternatives deemed relevant in the response.⁶ No other placement of *-mi* or *-ka* are felicitous in (3) or (4). Notice, however, that in ES we find a strategy to mark focus that is not common to all Spanish varieties: in (4b) we can see that the focused element (‘bread’) is placed in preverbal position instead of after the verb, which would be the default position in a SVO language, and thus the expected position in this context. Placing the object in preverbal position is not possible if the object is not focused.

In EAS there is no evidential system and *-mi*, which has been claimed to double as focus marker, has been lost together with other evidential markers. However, *-ka*, which was claimed to mark topic in Kichwa, is preserved in EAS. This said, the grammatical role of *-ka* is less clear in EAS than in Kichwa. *-Ka* in EAS has been claimed to mark either focus or (aboutness) topic, which are contradictory roles to play by a single marker. Furthermore, if *-ka* was a focus marker, we would be in the paradoxical situation in which a focus marker (*-mi*) is not preserved in a situation of language contact and a topic marker, *-ka*, is adopted to mark focus. Thus, the theoretical question we embark on is what exactly the role of *-ka* is in EAS. That is, whether *-ka* is truly a focus marker or a topic marker.

Preliminary introspective data extracted from interviews with EAS speakers shed some light on our query. Notice that in EAS, in (4b) above the inclusion of *-ka* would be possible in the object (the focus), but only if the speaker is to insist that it was bread what Christian ate, otherwise speakers report that *-ka* is too aggressive/emphatic (notice that *-ka* would be infelicitous in any other position for congruence reasons). B’s final utterance in the dialogue in (5) shows a natural use of *-ka*:

- (5) A: ¿Qué comió Christian? [EAS]
 ‘What did Christian eat?’
- B: Christian pan comió.
 ‘Christian ate bread.’
- A: ¡Ah! Christian comió papa.
 ‘Oh!, Christian ate potatoes.’
- B: ¡No! Christian pan-ka comió.
Neg Christian bread-ka eat.pas.3sg
 ‘No! It was bread what Christian ate.’

⁶ This is a simplification that applies to *direct* answers. The larger picture must address how indirect (partial) answers preserve congruence at some level. This broader discussion is left aside in this paper.

As (5) shows, in EAS *-ka* appears with a focus constituent, not with the sentential topic, as it would in Kichwa (see (4a)). Any other placement of *-ka* in B's last utterance in (5) would result in infelicity. This opens the door to the possibility of *-ka* in EAS not marking topic or focus, but something else, in particular, contrast. In fact, if this were the case, we would predict that in "contrastive topic" interpretations,⁷ we can find *-ka* without the need of conveying emphasis or insistence. This is indeed what our consultants report, see (6aii) and (6bii) (the (a) examples report responses in Kichwa and the (b) examples in EAS):

- (6) Contexto: usted vive solo con su hermano en la casa. Llegan a hacerle una encuesta del censo y le preguntan:

Context: You and your brother are the only people living in the house. Someone arrives to conduct a census survey, and asks:

A: Imata rura-ngui-chik tuta-manda-kuna? / ¿Qué hacen en las mañanas? [K/EAS]
what hacer-pres-2pl día-en el-2pl what do.pas.3pl in the mornings

a. i. B: Ñuka villa-man ri-ni [K]
I city-to go-1sg
 'I go to the city.'

ii. B: Ñuka-ka villa-man ri-ni, ñuka wawki-ka trabaja-shpa hausi-pi saquiri-n.
I-ka city-to ir-1sg my brother-ka work-ing house-in stay-s
 'About me, I go to the city; about my brother, he stays at home.'

b. i. B: Yo voy a la ciudad. [EAS]
I go.1sg to the city
 'I go to the city.'

ii. B: Yo-ka voy a la ciudad, mi hermano-ka se queda en casa trabajando. [EAS]
I-ka go.1sg to the city my brother-ka cl.3sg stay.3sg in house working
 'About me, I go to the city; about my brother, he stays home working.'

-Ka is not possible in (6bi) for the same reasons as it is not possible in (4b), it is to emphatic. However, once it is necessary to mark a contrast, as in (6bii), *-ka* is not just perfectly fine and does not trigger any emphatic inference, but it is necessary (its total absence would render the utterance infelicitous). (6bii) is perfect with *-ka* in both sentences, but it is also possible to have only one *-ka* placed in any of the two sentences (i.e., either *yo-ka* or *mi hermano-ka*).

If *-ka* marked contrast, then its grammatical role in EAS would directly capitalize on one of the properties it already had in Kichwa, where it is optional and, when *-ka* is present, it marks contrast. Based on this preliminary observation, we embarked on the task to confirm in our investigation the hypothesis that *-ka* is used to mark contrast in EAS. In the following section, we address the methodological challenges we faced when conducting fieldwork and the solutions that worked better for our study.

4. Fieldwork in a language-contact context

Our research started with data collected in sociolinguistic interviews conducted in 2018 and 2019. Part of those interviews addressed directly the meaning and function of *-ka* in EAS, trying to

⁷ Despite the name, Contrastive Topic refers to the coordination of two foci. See e.g., Constant (2014) for discussion of different approaches.

understand how this particle inherited from Kichwa was incorporated into EAS, and to what extent *-ka* has the same role/function in EAS as it does in Kichwa. As mentioned above, the particle *-ka* has been associated with information structure categories (*topic/focus*) in both Kichwa and EAS (Lipski, 2014; Muysken, 2019). However, as we saw in the previous section, the claims for the role of *-ka* in EAS are contradictory (it has been both claimed that it is a focus and a topic marker). Our investigation aims at understanding what the actual meaning contribution of *-ka* is in EAS.

In this section, we outline the thought process in the design of the different experimental tasks to be carried out in the field. It is important to note that we benefited from the invaluable collaboration of EAS and Kichwa speakers in different communities throughout this process. We had the help of six collaborators from Tungurahua, one from Cotopaxi, one from Quito, and three from Imbabura. They all contributed with their knowledge and comments, and guided us in our quest to design appropriate methodologies and materials to carry out empirical investigations in their communities.

Pilot studies

Our first approximation to this empirical investigation was a production task based on Question-Answer pairs, as explained in the previous section, building on Skopeteas et al.'s (2006) guidelines to conduct research on *information structure* categories. In particular, we built on the Questionnaire on Information Structure called *Who does What*. Based on this questionnaire, we presented participants with different pictures using Power Point slides. Participants had to listen to a question and were asked to provide a response by looking at the image (see Figure 1). They were instructed to give full answers, that is, to use a subject, a verb, and an object. Due to the worldwide Covid-19 emergency, the sessions were conducted and recorded via Zoom.

Figure 1

Example of an image used for pilot study 1 (image from Skopeteas et al., 2006).



Question: ¿Qué comió la mujer?
 ‘What did the woman eat?’

The task included 2 conditions: questions requiring subject focus in the response (e.g., *who ate the apple?*), and questions asking about the object, and thus requesting answers in which the object is the focus, as in Figure 1 (e.g., *what did the woman eat?*).

The rationale behind the design of this pilot study follows the layout of the theoretical assumptions laid out above. The goal in this task was to obtain data supporting our preliminary hypothesis regarding the strategies deployed by EAS speakers to mark focus. We expected to find SOV order in the responses when the object was the focus, and not otherwise. We also expected to see uses of *-ka* in the responses. The design would allow us to understand if *-ka* appeared with the focus constituent, the aboutness *topic*, or both, as claimed in the literature.

The results of pilot study 1 showed a strong preference for the canonical SVO word order in all the responses (the basic word order for ES and EAS, e.g., *la mujer come una manzana* / lit. *the woman eats an apple*) regardless of whether the subject or the object were to be congruent with the question. Regarding the use of *-ka*, no instances were produced in this task. This was running against the observed behavior during the sociolinguistic interviews and the behavior observed outside of the experimental setting.

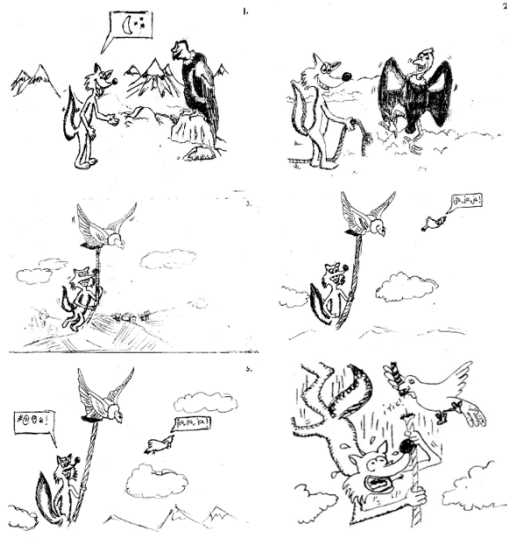
At the end of each experimental session participants were asked to provide feedback on the task itself. The first point mentioned was that the virtual setting was problematic. That is, participants felt uncomfortable having a virtual interaction because, at that point, they were not used to having video calls frequently (this pilot study was run at the beginning of the Covid-19 pandemic). In addition, participants commented that the experimental procedure, which involved a video call, was associated with a formal context (e.g., a work meeting) and not with an informal conversation. These participants try hard to use standard ES in formal settings and to avoid EAS features, as they consider those features to be ‘incorrect’. Another critical point raised by participants was that the task itself felt unnatural since they were asked to provide full sentences in their responses (i.e., sentences in which there would be an overt subject, object, and verb). The complaint was that they mostly produce fragment answers in those settings. If they are asked to spell out all constituents, they fall back to a “proper context”, a context in which they have to make use of “appropriate language” and, thus, the “correct” word order for them ought to be SVO, the ES basic word order. This impression of being in a “proper context” was further exacerbated by the experiment's design, in which participants were asked to answer a question based on a picture, which made them feel evaluated. That is, they felt that there was a “right” answer and, thus, that they did not want to fail to find it.

It is obvious, from the description of the participants’ feedback presented above, that speakers are highly constrained by the linguistic ideologies favoring ES and characterizing EAS as deficient. The three major problems were the procedure (use of teleconference), the instructions provided (use of fully spelled out sentences), and the question-answer nature of the task.

Based on the participants’ comments we designed another task trying to overcome the problems pointed out above. Following Muntendam (2009), participants were presented with a set of pictures that, together, were interpreted as a story (see Figure 2). Participants were first asked to tell a story based on the images.

Figure 2

Story 'La zorra y la lora' (The fox and the parrot) by Martínez Parra 1999. (Images from Muntendam, 2009).



After participants completed the first task, they were asked to perform two more tasks. Task 2a, required them to answer to a series of questions (uttered by the researcher) aimed at eliciting spontaneous answers while controlling for information focus and aboutness topic (e.g., *¿Qué cortó la lora?*, 'What did the parrot cut?') (See figure 3), as well as contrastive focus (e.g., *¿La zorra cortó la sogá?*, 'The fox cut the rope?', asked of a picture showing that it was a parrot who cut the rope). Participants were again instructed to use a full answer and avoid single word responses.

Figure 3

Example of an image used in Task 2a (Images from Muntendam, 2009).



The second task, task 2b, was a forced-choice judgement task in which they were presented with a picture, a question, and three potential answers varying in word order (see Figure 4). The researcher read the question and asked to participants to respond by reading the given options out-loud so they would choose the one that sounded more natural. At this point in the task *-ka* was not a concern, since

the goal was to establish focus marking strategies driven by word order and, as seen above, *-ka* is not licensed in these contexts. Just as in pilot 1, the sessions were conducted via Zoom and the tasks were presented on Power Point slides.

Figure 4.

Example of the forced-choice judgement task; translations added (images from Muntendam, 2009)

¿Qué corta la lora? 	• La lora la sogá corta. • La sogá corta la lora. • La lora corta la sogá.	‘What does the parrot cut?’ ‘The parrot the rope cuts.’ ‘The rope cuts the parrot.’ ‘The parrot cuts the rope.’
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The rationale behind the design of this experiment was to create a setting to which participants would feel more culturally related and relaxed (since they had to come up first with a story of their own), and to reduce the “formal context” effect triggered by the procedure identified in pilot 1. Participants reported that the contextualization of the story and the Question-Answer pairs were better, and they didn’t feel being “examined” in the same way. However, they still pointed out that restriction imposed to use of full spelled out sentences in their responses in task 2a felt unnatural. Additionally, they reported that they were aware of the inappropriateness of providing responses with any word order other than the canonical SVO, that it would be “incorrect”. Notice that this points out at a hypercorrection: in ES and in many varieties of Spanish word order is variable and, while SVO is the basic word order and has a broad distribution, deviation from this word order reflects additional information structural marking. Yet, these participants felt the need to use the canonical SVO word order at all times. This was reflected in their responses to the force-choice judgment task, 2b, in which canonical basic word order was the preferred choice. Additionally, participants felt confused by having to evaluate different sentences with different word orders (there were too many options). Finally, an important new source of concern was that some participants reported being insecure about reading the sentences and, in general, about reading out loud altogether. First, reading is not a common practice for these participants (more so in an experimental setting). Second, while the forced-choice task provided all possible word orders, the sentences were spelled out in standard Spanish spelling (either ES or Peninsular) which, as we in section 1, differs from EAS on the phonological properties and, thus, speakers were very wary of making “mistakes” when pronouncing the written text. Participants mentioned that they did their best to not ‘mispronounce’ some words while reading, especially the ones that contained /r/ or /ʎ/ sounds because they were afraid of ‘arrastrar’, i.e. the use of the assibilated form of those sounds, which is considered to be a characteristic of EAS (this is clearly an issue with words like *zorra*, ‘fox’, fig. 4, ES [sora], EAS [so.ɾa] or [so.ʎa]). Lastly, participants commented that having ‘virtual’ meetings are becoming more frequent among families and friends, but it is still considered ‘formal’.

On the other hand, participants' comments showed that the problems previously caused by the question-answer component in experiment 1 were considerably reduced in experiment 2 thanks to having considered a more culturally relatable context, and an approach that made participants feel more immersed in the task at hand. Yet, this part of the task still required improvement. Additionally, requesting participants to provide responses with fully spelled out constituents was still problematic. Finally, given that the world-wide Covid 19 pandemic had forced everybody to be more familiar with video-calls, having participants complete the tasks on this mode was better experience than what they experience with experiment 1, when participants were less familiarized with this practice, and it didn't feel very natural.

Following up on the participants' comments and building on Sánchez (2020) we designed a third task to try to overcome the problems that persisted. Participants were asked to 'pretend' they were on a video call with an old high-school friend (the researcher) in which they were 'gossiping' about what their old classmates had been up to. Participants listened to a question and were asked to provide an answer by looking at the front page of an Ecuadorian newspaper called *El Herald* (Figure 5).⁸ The experimental items consisted of front pages from *El Herald* (see fig. 5) varying on the news portrayed and, within the news portrayed, the word order in the headline and the presence/absence of *-ka*. During the conversation the researcher pretended not to be aware of the news and asked the participant (who had the relevant news portrayed in the newspaper front-page in front of them) what had happened. Participants were told to provide answers with the phrasing they considered appropriate with the only condition of avoiding one-word answers. The task was presented in Power Point slides and the sessions were conducted via Zoom.

Figure 5.

Newspaper cover elaborated for the task.



⁸ *El Herald* is an actual newspaper focusing on news from the Central Highlands in Ecuador. It is known for its coverage of national and, crucially, local news. Locals often pay to advertise or announce events such as kids' graduations, or defuncions.

During the conversation, the researcher elicited information focus as well as contrastive focus answers (the latter were elicited by pretending not to have understood well what was said). Within each subtype of focus, two conditions were considered: focus on the subject (subject focus) and on the object (object focus). The questions used to elicit information focus were phrased differently from the phrasing in the previous pilot studies (*Me contaron que el Manuel compró algo, ¿sabes qué?*, ‘I heard that Manuel bought something, do you know what?’), while for contrastive focus contexts declarative questions were used (e.g., *¿Manuel compró una casa?*, ‘Manuel bought a house?’). These last questions are equivalent to English Rising Declaratives, which require context-bias to be licensed. For illustration, in the running example the researcher pretended that what they understood that had been said was that Manuel had bought a house, which contrasts with what the participant reported following the newspaper’s front page provided, which was that Manuel had bought a parcel of land.

The rationale for this task's design was to reduce the effects of the instructions and the virtual setting where the sessions were performed. In this experiment we took advantage of the video call to frame the conversation in a more relaxed context where two friends were ‘gossiping’. Also, participants were instructed to use any phrasing in the responses, so they felt more relaxed during the task and thus contributing to reducing the perceived level of formality. Participants mentioned that the context of ‘gossiping’ and having a local newspaper in the task reduced the ‘unnaturalness’ of the previous tasks. However, they pointed out that they felt distracted with the headlines, and that sometimes the headlines were confusing due to the word order variation and the presence of *-ka*. In the context of a newspaper, language ideologies, beliefs about language and ideas about what is considered appropriate/inappropriate get activated, determining what is acceptable (Irvine & Gal 2000). In this context, a newspaper headline, speakers reported that non-standard word orders, “deviant” from the standard, and other linguistic features not present in ES, such as *-ka*, were not expected to be found. Finding these elements on the front page of a newspaper was “odd” and inappropriate.

A final comment about this task's design was that printed newspapers are becoming obsolete. Younger generations do not buy or read printed newspapers because most of the information is received through electronic devices, especially through social networks. In this sense, participants suggested that the same context, getting information about others or ‘gossiping’, is more related to social media nowadays, at least for those people who have access and make use of social media.

To summarize, there were three major challenges at the initial stage of this study. One was the instructions that asked participants for full responses that contained all elements (they should be fully spelled out sentences). This was slightly modified so participants would feel free to use any phrasing they may prefer. The second issue was related to the procedure, which included Question-Answers in a video call. We tried to overcome this in the last experiment by embedding the Question-Answer dynamics within the context of the task, i.e., the experimenter played the role of an old friend who has not been in touch for a long time and wanted to catch up. This alleviated the awkwardness of these question-answer dynamics and created a sense of naturalness, a context that was more relatable. However, problems related to language ideologies still arose in this task: there are varieties that “can’t” be used in print media and, thus, can’t appear on a newspaper’s front page. Participants observed that *-ka*, and word orders other than the canonical SVO should not be used in print media despite the fact that

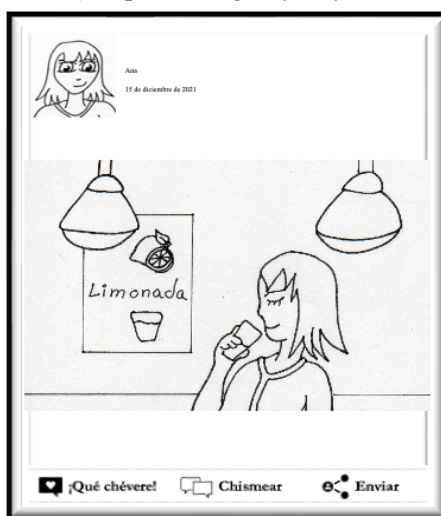
people actually use it in daily interaction. With all the lessons learned from these three pilot studies we designed a last task, which we describe in the following section.

5. Tasks with a Community-Based and Save-Face Approach to experimental methodologies: Gossiping through social media and playing ‘otherness’

This final task was designed thanks to the feedback provided by participants during the pilot studies, which is the core of the *Community Based Approach* to experimental methodologies (CBA). In the final design, we used pictures from a (look alike) social media platform (strikingly looking like Facebook), see figure 6.⁹ The participant would use posts from this social network as the source for the information they would give their friend, the character interpreted by the researcher. The rationale behind this task was to overcome the challenges of having to embed a Question-Answer dynamics within the task, as well as the dissonance produced by having a particular language variety in written form. For the procedure, we incorporated background information about the interlocutors and the context in which the interaction occurred. The background information consisted of two old high-school friends gossiping. They were talking via Zoom because one of them had emigrated from Ecuador, and he wanted to know about four friends they had in common. The participant had access to the social media profiles of the people that they were asked about, which was not the case for the character interpreted by the researcher. This social-media set-up was meant to overcome the anachronic factor introduced by traditional newspapers in the previous design. Overall, this “gossip” set-up provided a familiar practice for participants allowing them to engage in conversation in a more casual way. In fact, participants commented that this framing was close to the reality of community members. Social media has become a common way to get the news about close friends and, in general, of the relevant local and national matters. They have also become an important communication tool, especially during the COVID-19 pandemic.

Figure 6.

Example of an experimental item (Graphic design by Bryan Puma Ninacuri).



⁹ If we were to conduct this experiment again, we would probably have to adapt the materials to make them look more like other competing platforms.

This final version has two conditions, the subtype of focus (information and contrastive focus), and the focus constituent (subject and object), and it was divided into two parts. The first part aimed at eliciting only information focus marking. Participants were asked to respond to a series of questions uttered by the researcher (e.g., *Me contaron que Ana tomó algo, ¿sabes qué?*, ‘I was told that Ana drank something, do you know what?’). The second aimed at eliciting contrastive focus. The researcher would say that they wanted to make sure they had understood correctly what the participant had said and proceeded to elicit information using a tag question, e.g., *Ana tomó un té, ¿no es cierto?* (‘Ana had a tea, didn’t she?’).

Originally, the task was planned to take place in a single session; however, participants still felt nervous and evaluated at the beginning of the session (as natural as the task may have seemed, participants were conscious of being part of a language study). To ease things out, instead of starting out with the experimental task, we started the interaction with the participant by conducting a short sociolinguistic interview. In this way, the participant could get acquainted with the researcher and fall back to a relaxed, casual mode before starting the experimental task in which the participant had to talk to the researcher as if he were a friend (the experiment would thus capitalize on this initial interaction). The goal was to reduce participants’ stress and awareness during the session. The interview consisted of different topics such as narrating an experience or anecdote in the past, talking about traditions and festivities in the city, or describing their neighborhood and how it has changed over the years. The session time distribution consisted of 20-30 minutes for the interview and 15-20 for the experimental task. After implementing these changes, EAS features such as non-canonical word orders to mark focus (see example 7), and sporadically, the use of *-ka*, started being produced.

- (7) A: *Me contaron que Ana tomó algo, ¿sabes qué?*,
 ‘I was told that Ana drank something, do you know what?’
 B: (Ana) *un juguito tomó*.
 Lit. ‘Ana a juice drank’

Regarding the use of *-ka*, this feature was rarely produced by participants, and this could be explained by the participants’ awareness of the stigma associated with its use (*-ka* is more salient as an EAS emblem than other linguistic features). In fact, during our conversations, participants associated this particle’s use with people who are less educated, have a lower socioeconomic status, and live in rural areas. These comments about the use of *-ka* were also voiced during our pilot studies. Participants recognized that this particle is used among community members, but they also acknowledged that its usage is ‘incorrect’ or considered ‘not proper Spanish’, spelling out in this way the undercurrent language ideologies embodied by ES (the standard). Importantly, when *-ka* was included, it was always attached to the focus constituent in contrastive-focus contexts.

Considering this information we implemented the *Saving Face Approach* (SFA) to experimental tasks. We designed a judgment task in the form of a role play task. The idea behind this task was to avoid the “shame” that the participant may feel by using a stigmatized form. Participants were asked to evaluate whether a particular sentence could be produced by members of their community in the context provided. In this way, we could obtain their judgments while they would not be “guilty” of using the “inappropriate” form. Crucially, all participants providing judgments had spontaneously used *-ka* while

informally talking to the researcher. This allows us to conclude that the judgments provided in this task are accurate, as we knew that *-ka* is part of their grammar.

The task consisted of question-answer pairs, in which participants evaluated the grammaticality of sentences as if they were another person in their community. Example (8) shows one experimental item (see below for how they were presented).

- (8) A. ¿Qué compró Lupita?
 ‘What did Lupita buy?’
- a. Lupita compró libros.
 - b. Lupita-ka compró libros.
 - c. Lupita compró libros-ka.
- Lit. ‘Lupita bought books’
- d. Lupita libros compró.
 - e. Lupita libros-ka compró.
 - f. Lupita-ka libros compró.
- Lit. ‘Lupita books bought’

The items were presented to the participants in Power Point slides in a written format. However, taking into consideration the literacy issues pointed out by participants in the pilot studies, we adopted a ‘role play’ technique to obtain judgments. Each slide contained a question and the possible variations in the answer appeared one at a time. The participant was given time to read the answer provided. Once the participant signaled that they had read and understood the answer provided, the researcher started the role play enacting the question naturally. At that point the participant responded with the answer provided. If the answer, as given, did not agree with how a community member could respond to such given question, the participant made a comment on it (that is, participants were allowed to not reproduce patterns that did not agree with their intuitions). Once a given answer was evaluated this way, it disappeared, and an alternative response appeared. There were cases in which the researcher and the participants would switch roles to create a more engaging activity.

To illustrate the process more precisely, let us take the example in (8). Participants observed that while (8e) could marginally be a possible response in which *-ka* could potentially appear, there were more specific contexts in which *-ka* would be more natural. This was predicted in the original hypothesis and, consequently, we had prepared more elaborate contexts, see (9), which were presented at this point.

- (9) Contexto: Ana y María fueron a comprar útiles escolares en una papelería donde trabaja su amiga, Carmen. Carmen no sabe qué compraron porque fue su día libre, por lo que Carmen pregunta a una de sus compañeras que sí estuvo presente ese día:

Context: Ana and Maria went to buy school supplies at a store where their friend, Carmen, works. Carmen doesn't know what they bought because it was her day off, so Carmen asks one of her coworkers, who was there that day:

A: ¿Quién compró qué?

‘Who bought what?’

B: Ana(-ka) libros compró, María(-ka) no sé.

Lit. ‘Ana(-ka) books bought, María(-ka), I do not know.’

The example in (9) provides a suitable context for a complex question (e.g., *who bought what?*), one that enforces a contrastive topic interpretation of B’s response. Participants mentioned that in this context, *-ka* has to appear, and it could be attached to *Ana*, to *María*, or to both. While the full report on the results is beyond this paper’s scope, let us note that the overall results confirmed our initial hypothesis as said above in section 3.

By letting speakers report on how *others*, who the researchers knew to be members of the same speech community, would place *-ka*, while not committing themselves to the same practice (and thus self-inflict the stigma), we lowered the participants’ stress and anxiety: it was not them who used the stigmatized form, but others in their community. Importantly, as said above, given that the participants had already spontaneously used *-ka* in previous informal interactions with the researcher, we can conclude that the data provided accurately portrays the grammar of information structure marking in EAS: the *others* are members of their own speech community.

During this task we could appreciate the participants’ strong awareness of language ideologies, and we were able to observe how the SFA allowed participants to comment more freely on the variety under study. Participants did not only provide judgments about sentences, but also reflected on the language itself and provided additional metalinguistic comments regarding the use of certain features during the session. For example, participants often commented that ‘scrambled’ word order (what participants referred to as *hablar al revés*, lit. *to talk backwards*) is commonly used when answering a question (see (8d)), while immediately pointing out that such manipulation is not ‘proper’ Spanish. Similarly, participants acknowledged that *-ka* is used among community members, but that its use is considered incorrect and that they should avoid using it. They also mentioned that this particle is mostly used in rural areas or produced by people who are members of specific groups (e.g., Kichwa-Spanish speakers, people who live in rural areas, less educated people, or merchants).

In sum, implementing Community-Based and Saving-Face Approaches to experimental methodologies has allowed us to overcome the challenges faced at the beginning of this research. With all the lessons learned, as well as the contribution of community members, we modified the tasks and procedures to overcome the three challenges encountered.

6. Conclusions

The first overall lesson from our investigation is that to conduct experimental tasks under controlled linguistic conditions, capitalizing on the community’s everyday linguistic practices reduces participants’ self-awareness. This approach leads to a collection of data that more accurately represents the participants’ actual linguistic patterns. This is the principle behind what we term *Community Based Approach* to experimental methodologies. To design experimental tasks with this approach, it is crucial that the researcher gets to know the community that will participate in the study. This can be done by conducting ethnographic fieldwork and by working together with community members in task-design

development. This collaborative work helped us overcome the challenges faced at the initial stages of the research, and let us uncover other issues such as the undercurrent linguistic ideologies shared by speech community members legitimizing the standard ES.

The second lesson refers to the importance of letting speakers distance themselves from stigmatized behavior. Researchers cannot change the social environment in which participants are embedded, or free them from the language ideologies they have come to accept (i.e., the language ideologies active in the speech community). When a language is stigmatized, we cannot expect their speakers to forget about the stigma carried by reproducing its emblematic features. We can, however, request their expert information without making them feel “ashamed”. This is the principle behind the *Saving Face Approach* to experimental methodologies.

The combine use of these approaches to experimental methodologies guided us in the design of the experimental tasks. They allowed us to reduce the level of participants’ awareness of their own speech variety and led to successful data collection.

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